TEACHER GUIDE

OCR GCSE (9-1) in Business (J204)

Organisational structure

3. People
3.2 Organisational structures and different ways of working



A revision lesson. Pupils run a car dealership in firms of four and revise organisational structure on their own deals. Seat each firm together. Each firm answers the topic tasks together.

The lesson

45-minute setting

Setup	Round 1	Round 2	Round 3	Final questions

EVERY ROUND

Firm decisions
3 min

→

Deals
4½–5 min

→

Topic tasks
4 min

→

B2B deal
2½ min
from Round 2

LESSON SETTINGS

30 min	45 min	60 min	75 min

What pupils do

Every pupil buys and sells cars. In Firm decisions, each role has its own job.



CEO

Staff · Sabotage from Round 2



Finance

Capital & Loans · Investments



Sales & Marketing

Marketing



Operations

Seasonal stock

Topic tasks

Each firm gets its own figures. The method is the same.

1 Too wide a span

Round 1

Your sales manager leads 15 staff and has no time to coach the new ones.

Which change would help most?

A Widen the span of control further
B Move all decisions to head office
C Remove the sales manager's post
D Add a team leader for some staff

ANSWER
✓ Add a team leader for some staff

Why: A narrower span gives each manager time for each worker.

2 Flatter structure

Round 1

You remove a layer of managers.

Which two effects are most likely?

A Narrower spans of control
B Closer supervision of staff
C More chances of promotion
D Lower management costs
E Messages travel faster

ANSWER
✓ Lower management costs
✓ Messages travel faster

Why: Fewer layers: quicker messages and fewer managers to pay, but wider spans.

3 Chain of command

Round 2

A salesperson's idea goes up the chain of command.

Put the route in order, first to last?

A The sales team leader
B The branch manager
C The managing director
D The salesperson

ANSWER
1. The salesperson
2. The sales team leader
3. The branch manager
4. The managing director

Why: The chain of command runs from the bottom of the structure to the top.

Topic tasks

4 Delayering saving

Round 2

You remove a layer of supervisors.

Yearly saving in pay?

Supervisors removed	**5 staff**
Pay of each, a year	**£22,500**
Managers who take their staff	**3 staff**
Pay rise for each manager	**£3,000**

ANSWER

£103,500

5 × £22,500 − 3 × £3,000 = £103,500

Why: Delayering cuts pay costs, but each manager now leads more staff.

5 Who sets prices

Round 3

Head office sets every branch's prices. One branch keeps losing sales to a cheaper local rival.

What should you change, and why?

A Let the branch set its prices

B Keep all pricing at head office

ANSWER

✓ Let the branch set its prices

Why: The manager who knows local buyers can react faster.

6 Tall structure

Round 3

Your firm has six layers, and each manager has only three staff.

Which problem is most likely?

A Too few chances of promotion

B Staff given too much freedom

C Managers too busy to supervise

D Slow decisions through many layers

ANSWER

✓ Slow decisions through many layers

Why: Narrow spans make a tall structure, so messages pass many people.

Final questions

Each pupil answers 6 final questions on organisational structure. They come from these 7 questions.

1. Tall means many levels; flat, few. Worked case: a six-level chain takes a week to decide a branch request. A group cuts two of five levels. Gain and cost?
   ✔ **Faster decisions, but fewer promotion steps and less supervision**

2. A dealer group has six levels from technician to chief executive. Which type of structure is this?
   ✔ **A tall (hierarchical) structure**

3. What is an advantage of a flat structure for a small dealership?
   ✔ **Messages pass quickly between staff and the owner**

4. What is a drawback of a tall structure for a national dealer group?
   ✔ **Decisions take longer to pass down the levels**

5. What does an organisation chart of a dealership show?
   ✔ **Who reports to whom in the business**

6. A dealer group removes its layer of regional managers. What is the most likely effect?
   ✔ **Branch managers report straight to head office**

7. An organisation chart shows a chief executive, 3 managers under her and 5 staff under each manager. How many people are on the chart?
   ✔ **19 people**